The problem of consciousness; philosophical and empirical aspects

1FL119, Umeå University, HT 2026

Teachers: Bram Vaassen, Johan Eriksson, Fabiana Caserta

Course Description

This course is a specialisation in the philosophy of mind, focusing on the "subjective" aspects of the mind, i.e., "what it is like" to (say) feel pain or see colours. The central topic driving the course is how consciousness relates to the brain. Can consciousness be identified with some brain process, or is the relation between consciousness and the brain of some other kind? Perhaps more like the relationship between software and hardware? The course also addresses issues about the nature of consciousness itself and our epistemic access to it: to what extent can we come to know and understand consciousness and its relation to the brain? The course covers both philosophical and empirical contributions to these issues.

Class Set-Up & Examination

The class consists mainly of teacher-led lectures and prescribed readings per theme. To successfully complete the class, you have to fulfil five requirements:

1. Active participation in class discussions.
2. Write a very short paper (150-300 words);
3. Write two short papers (500-700 words);
4. Write a draft and a final paper (2000-3000 words);
5. Provide written feedback on a classmate's draft paper;

I have two reasons for having multiple writing assignments: First, people learn more if they actively engage with a topic. Doing four writing assignments on four different arguments will force you to think more deeply about these arguments. Second, philosophical writing is very peculiar. Starting with some shorter assignments will help those of you with less background in philosophy to get used to this kind of writing.

1. *Active participation*

   Read every assigned text and be prepared to answer the following questions:
   - What is the main argument in the text?
   - What did you find most interesting about the text?
   - What did you find most unclear?

   You don't have to write down your answers, but you must be able to provide them when asked.

2. *Very short paper*

   Philosophy is about creating and criticizing arguments. This assignment is meant to help you practice the skill of 'reconstructing an argument'. An argument consists of a thesis and reasons for believing the thesis. Pick any argument from the readings covered so far and describe it as accurately and concisely as you can. The key questions you should answer are: What is the argument's conclusion? What reasons does it offer in support of this conclusion? Suggestions for topics will be provided on canvas.

   Your very short paper must be on a different argument than your short papers.

   The very short paper is **due Tuesday, November 10th**.

3. *Short papers*

   This assignment is meant to help you practice the skill of critiquing an argument that you will need for the final paper. Pick any argument from the readings and describe it as accurately and concisely as you can (just as for the previous assignment). But now you also need to add what you take to be the strongest objection to the argument. What is the argument's conclusion? What do you think is the strongest objection to the argument? Which of the assumptions the argument is making is weakest and why? Suggestions for topics will be provided on Canvas.

   Your two short papers must be on different arguments, and on a different argument than your very short paper.

   Short papers 1 and 2 are due **Thursday, November 26th and Thursday, December 10th**, respectively.

4. Draft and Final Paper

   In this assignment you need to demonstrate your skill for reconstructing and evaluating arguments that you have practised in the previous assignments. You need to write a draft and a final paper of about 2000-3000 words. Like for the previous assignments, you can pick any argument you want from the course literature. This time you need to do four things: (i) explain the argument as clearly as you can; (ii) raise what you take to be the strongest objection to the argument; (iii) explain what you take to be the best reply to this objection; and (iv) end with an overall evaluation of the argument: Does the argument succeed to show what it is meant to show?

   Your final paper must be on a different argument than the other assignments.

   A draft of your paper is due **Sunday, December 20th** (the draft should be at least 1000 words long).

   The final paper is due **Thursday, January 14th, 2027**.

5. Feedback

   For this requirement, I will match you up with a 'feedback partner' on canvas. You will provide feedback on the draft of one fellow student and receive feedback from one student. The length of your comments should be about half of the length of the paper.

   Providing and receiving feedback is incredibly important for improving one's writing. Often when I try to give feedback on someone else's writing, I discover problems with my own writing. Noticing what makes another paper difficult to read helps you realize that you might be doing the same thing. (For some reason, we are better at spotting faults in others than in ourselves.) At the same time, receiving feedback will help you improve your paper. Please be kind when you give and receive feedback. I get very frustrated when someone misunderstands what I was trying to say. But then it also teaches me that maybe I did not say it as clearly as I should have.

   Your paper feedback is due **Friday, January 8th, 2027**.

For a passing grade, the following criteria must be met on all assignments, except for active participation:

- Demonstrate in-depth knowledge of the relevant course material
- Precise referencing to the literature, including exact page numbers

- Writing of academic quality

For VG, all of these criteria need to be met to a significantly high degree.

Course Schedule with Reading Instructions

As a general rule, the class meets Tuesdays and Fridays at 10:15. We will take a break from this on November 10th.

Readings marked with * are available via Canvas. All others are available through the university library online service. There are hyperlinks to the relevant webpages in the schedule below. If you click on the titles of the texts, you will be redirected to the online repository of the University Library.

To some extent, this schedule is preliminary, as we may get behind schedule on the readings. If this affects the readings for next week, this will be clearly communicated in the lectures.

Lecture 1: What is phenomenal consciousness?

Tuesday, November 3rd · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten)

- Chalmers, D., (1996) *The Conscious Mind: In Search of a Fundamental Theory*, Oxford: Oxford UP. Introduction + chapter 1.
- *Palmer, S., (1999) Vision Science: Photons to Phenomenology, Cambridge, Mass. MIT Press. Sections 13.2-13.3.

Lecture 2: What is the problem of consciousness?

Friday, November 6th · 10:15–12:00 · BET.F.202

- *Kripke, S., (1980) *Naming and Necessity*, Harvard University Press, pp. 144–155.
- Jackson, F., (1982) Epiphenomenal Qualia, *Philosophical Quarterly*, 32(127): 127–136.
- Papineau, D., (2002) *Thinking about Consciousness*, Oxford UP. Chapter 1.

VERY SHORT PAPER DUE: TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 10TH

Lecture 3: Taking consciousness seriously; dualism and panpsychism

Friday, November 13th · 10:15–12:00 · BET.F.108

- *Chalmers, D., (2013) Panpsychism and Panprotopsychism
- Mørch H., *Non-physicalist Theories of Consciousness*. Cambridge University Press; 2024. **Ch 4**

Lecture 4: Taking physicalism seriously; functionalism and identity

Tuesday, November 17th · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten)

- Smart, J. J. C. (1959). Sensations and Brain Processes. *The Philosophical Review*, 68(2), 141–156.
- Levin, J., Functionalism, *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Summer 2023 Edition), Edward N. Zalta & Uri Nodelman (eds.) **Sections 1–3**

Lecture 5: Explaining what-it-is-likeness; representationalism

Friday, November 20th · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten)

- Harman, Gilbert (1990) "The intrinsic quality of experience," in. J. Tomberlin (ed.) *Philosophical Perspectives* 4. Ridgeview, 31-52. **Read only until page 40**.
- Kind, Amy (2010) "Transparency and Representationalist Theories of Consciousness", *Philosophy Compass* 5: 902–913.

Lecture 6: Explaining that-it-is-likeness; broadcasting and higher-order theories

Tuesday, November 24th · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten)

- *Rosenthal, D. (2002) Explaining consciousness, *Philosophy of Mind*, ed. Chalmers, Oxford UP.
- Neander, K. 1998. The Division of Phenomenal Labor: A Problem for Representationalist Theories of Consciousness. *Philosophical Perspectives* 12 (S12): 411–34.

Short paper 1 due: Thursday, November 26th

Lecture 7: Measures of Consciousness

Friday, November 27th · 10:15–12:00 · BET.F.108 · Guest lecture: Johan Eriksson

- * Stockart, F., et al. (2025). Studying unconscious processing: Contention and consensus. *The Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 1–77.
- Bayne, T., et al. (2024). Tests for consciousness in humans and beyond. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*, 28(5), 454–466.

Lecture 8: Neural Correlates of Consciousness

Tuesday, December 1st · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten) · Guest lecture: Johan Eriksson

- Storm, J. F., et al. (2024). An integrative, multiscale view on neural theories of consciousness. *Neuron* (Cambridge, Mass.), 112(10), 1531–1552.

Lecture 9: Explaining the gap; phenomenal concepts, illusionism and ignorantism

Friday, December 4th · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten)

- Papineau, D., (2002) *Thinking about Consciousness*, Oxford UP. Sections 2.1-2.6
- Kammerer, F., (2019). The illusion of conscious experience. *Synthese* 198 (1):845-866.
- Sundström, P. (2018). How Physicalists Can—and Cannot—Explain the Seeming "Absurdity" of Physicalism. *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research*, 97(3), 681–703.

Lecture 10: Global vs. local states of consciousness

Tuesday, December 8th · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten) · Guest lecture: Fabiana Caserta

- Bayne, T., & Hohwy, J. (2016). Modes of Consciousness. In *Finding Consciousness*. Oxford University Press.
- McKilliam, A. K. (2020). What is a global state of consciousness? *Philosophy and the Mind Sciences*, 1(II), Article 7.

Short paper 2 due: Thursday, December 10th

Lecture 11: Is AI conscious?

Friday, December 11th · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten)

- *Chalmers, David J. (2023). Could a large language model be conscious? *Boston Review* 1.

- Seth, A. (2026). Conscious artificial intelligence and biological naturalism. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 49.

Lecture 12: Q&A

Tuesday, December 15th · 10:15–12:00 · HUM.F.134 (Lingvisten)

We will go through any remaining course content or questions you might have about the final assignment.

Paper draft due: Sunday, December 20th
Feedback due: Friday, January 8th, 2027
Final paper due: Thursday, January 14th, 2027

Deadlines Overview

- Very short paper: Tuesday, November 10th
- Short paper 1: Thursday, November 26th
- Short paper 2: Thursday, December 10th
- Paper draft: Sunday, December 20th
- Feedback: Friday, January 8th, 2027
- Final paper: Thursday, January 14th, 2027

Academic Policy

- *Academic Integrity*:
  Cheating and plagiarism are reported immediately. The universities' policy regarding cheating and plagiarism can be found here: https://www.umu.se/student/stod-och-hjalp/dina-rattigheter-och-skyldigheter/fusk-och-plagiat/ Aside from these general regulations, I will make it very clear what the demands on each examination are.
- *LLMs and Chatbot use*:
  All submissions will be tested for AI use. Current availability of chatbots like ChatGPT, Claude, and CoPilot create many grey area cases for cheating. Precise guidelines for how (not) to use them are posted on the Canvas page. Let me just reiterate here that your assignments must be of your own creation and having chatbots write them for you constitutes cheating as much as having someone else write your exams. This course provides you with exercises in philosophical writing and thinking. Having someone or something else do the writing for you would defeat the purpose of the course entirely.
- *Late essays or submissions*:
  I do not accept late essays or submissions. There are re-examinations and make-up exams for those who cannot meet the deadlines. Exceptions are of course made for those with valid grounds for the delay.
- *Access*:
  All relevant information will be available on the Canvas page. If, for any reason, the information or course literature is not available to you, you may contact the responsible teacher and/or the subject's study advisor for assistance.

Contact Information

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